



A PLAIN-LANGUAGE SNAPSHOT

Cogwheel's List

As we understand it, 20 August 2026

For a non-technical reader · Decisions locked through Question 6



CHAPTER ONE

The idea in one minute

Cogwheel's List is a quiet macOS companion. It keeps Apple Contacts and one Google Sheet in step with each other, the way iCloud keeps your iPhone and your Mac in step — except one of the two homes is a spreadsheet.

You do not edit people inside Cogwheel. You keep using the Contacts app you already know. You keep using the spreadsheet you already share. Cogwheel's job is the middle: watch both places, carry a change from one to the other, and stop honestly when the two sides disagree.

That is the whole product as it stands today. It is a relay, not a new address book, not a new spreadsheet, and not a third place to type a phone number.

Joe's direction for version 1: build the most Apple-like way to sync. In practice that means both directions, from the first release, covering people, groups, membership, and photographs — not a one-way export, and not “people now, groups later.”

CHAPTER TWO

A day with it

You change a card

You open Contacts on the Mac, update a mobile number, and close the window. Cogwheel notices. On the next successful run it writes that same number into the matching row of the Google Sheet. Nobody copies and pastes.

Someone changes the sheet

A colleague who can already see the spreadsheet corrects a spelling in a name. Cogwheel notices. It writes that spelling back into Apple Contacts. The Contacts app remains the place you look at a person's face and tap a number.

You add a person, or you remove one

A new card in Contacts becomes a new row. A new row that represents a person becomes a new card. If a person who was already linked disappears from one side, Cogwheel treats that as a delete and carries it to the other side. It does not guess. After the deletion has been absent on both sides for three clean successful runs, Cogwheel may forget the record of that deletion and move on.



You do not open a second copy

Version 1 is one Apple account and one Google account, on one running copy of the app. If a second copy of Cogwheel tries to start, it stops. Two writers of the same machine columns would silently fight. The app refuses that fight.

CHAPTER THREE

What actually moves

Think of a contact card the way Contacts already thinks of it: a name, company, notes, and then labeled pieces — a mobile phone, a work email, a home address. Each labeled piece is its own small fact. If you change the mobile number and someone else changes the work email, those are two different facts. One can travel; the other can wait.

Groups are first class, not a footnote. A group is its own kind of thing, with its own identity, living on a dedicated Groups sheet. Membership — this person belongs to that group — is its own small fact as well. Nested groups exist only as macOS already offers them. Account containers are a write destination, not a third spreadsheet.

Photographs stay in Contacts, where Apple already stores them. The Sheet records only whether a photo is present and a fingerprint of it. Google's spreadsheet service has no honest way for Cogwheel to insert a picture into a cell, and we will not add a second writer (a hidden script) to fake one. Presence and sameness are enough for the relay to know whether the picture on the card still matches.

When a new kind of labeled field appears on a card, the Sheet grows a new column for it. Columns are not renamed later. If a field changes type — a phone that becomes an email, in the rare case the system allows it — that is a new column, not a rewrite of an old one.

CHAPTER FOUR

When both sides change

Most of the time only one side moved. That change simply travels. If both sides ended up the same, even by different routes, Cogwheel notes that they agree and continues.

If both sides changed the same small fact and the two new values are genuinely different, Cogwheel does not pick a winner. It freezes that one fact and marks it, by name, as in conflict. You decide. The rest of the card keeps moving.

This is less automatic than some iCloud behavior, on purpose. A silent winner would be convenient until the day it is wrong. Version 1 would rather stop on that one cell and let a person choose.

CHAPTER FIVE

What it will not do

- It will not become a contact editor. The Contacts app is the human interface.
- It will not become a spreadsheet editor. You already have Google Sheets.
- It will not invent a second Google or Apple account in version 1.
- It will not let two copies of itself run at once.
- It will not put photographs into the Sheet as pictures.
- It will not quietly prefer one side when two edits collide.
- It will not keep growing without a ceiling; if its private records overflow the allowed size, it stops closed rather than guessing.
- It will not reopen the decisions on this page unless you reopen them.

CHAPTER SIX

Decisions already made

These are the locks as of 20 August 2026. They are written here in ordinary language so a reader who will never open a specification can still see the shape.

QUESTION	IN PLAIN LANGUAGE
Accounts	One Apple account and one Google account. Sharing the Sheet with other people is Google's job. Cogwheel alone writes its own tracking columns. A second running copy stops.
License	Hummingbird License version 1.6, or a newer All Licenses edition if one exists. No special exceptions.
Identity	Each person is remembered by Apple's own contact identifier and by a permanent Cogwheel identifier on the Sheet. That Sheet identifier is never rewritten. Missing or duplicated identifiers stop the app.
Disagreement and deletion	Compare against the last version both sides successfully agreed on. One sided edits travel. Matching values count as agreement. A true clash freezes that one fact. No automatic winner. A linked person who then goes missing is a delete. Forgotten deletions may be dropped after three clean runs on both sides.
The grain of a fact	A fact is one property, on one labeled value, of one type — for example the mobile phone, not “all phones.”



QUESTION	IN PLAIN LANGUAGE
Groups	Groups are their own kind of identity, on their own sheet, with membership as its own fact. Nested groups are a Mac-only idea. Account containers are only a place to write.
Photographs	The picture lives in Contacts. The Sheet stores presence and a fingerprint. No picture insert through Sheets, and no hidden second writer.
How it grows	New columns appear when new fields appear, in a determined order. A type change is a new column. The private records have a published size ceiling and stop closed if they would exceed it.
The feel of version 1	Apple-like: both directions, Contacts as the human face, full schema from day one. Engineering may build it in slices. The shipped product is not a one-way dump and not "people only."

CHAPTER SEVEN

Trust, size, and license

Cogwheel keeps a private notebook of what it last successfully applied, so it can tell a new edit from an old one. Every remembered fact is fingerprinted. That notebook is allowed to grow with the number of people, groups, pending deletions, and facts — and it is not allowed to grow past a published ceiling. If it would, the app stops closed. That is a safety behavior, not a suggestion.

The software is source available under the Hummingbird License, U.S. Edition, version 1.6, or a newer All Licenses edition if one is published. There are no carve-outs from that choice.

This booklet describes Cogwheel's List as currently understood. It is not the specification, and it does not invent policy. The numbered platform documents in the public repository remain the binding text. Further items in the eleven-point assignment will extend this picture; they have not arrived yet.



Colophon

Written 20 August 2026 from the locked questions and the platform documents 002 through 011 in the Cogwheels List repository. Produced for a non technical reader. Typeset in New York and Avenir Next. The cover still life is an original photograph style illustration of a contact card, a ledger, and two brass gears — the two homes, and the relay between them.

Repository · github.com/jja-jb/Cogwheels-List